

to a 4K TV in the next 3-5 years. 4K TVs and LED TVs in general are expected to get a lot cheaper in India over the next 2 years and you will be able to shorten your upgrade cycle due to the upcoming crash in big screen TV prices.

Inexpensive 4K TVs can be evil:

Low-cost 4K TVs often come with crappy panels that only support 4K at 30 Hz, that is basically limiting the video playback to a 30 Hz refresh rate per second. And, they suffer from awful judder when playing fast action content (sports channels, content that contains rapid panning, etc.). What's worse, many of them come with default up-scaling, so when set to 4K, they upscale SD and HD content to 4K and hence force the 30hz refresh rate on regular content as well, adding the same awful judder to everything that plays on it. The minimum refresh rate that you should settle for for ANY LED TV you buy should be at least 50/60 Hz at all resolutions supported.

Smart TVs can be useful but don't expect them to be 'Smart':

If you want your TV to offer wireless connectivity for internet access and connecting other devices (phones, laptops, media streamers, etc), a smart TV will help. Smart TVs offer built-in Wi-Fi and device-to-device wireless connectivity via common standards such as WiDi, Miracast, etc. One of our primary complaints about a lot of Smart TVs is on the interface and usability area. Smart TVs either offer a customised interface or a Smart OS, a layer that allows you to use the additional features of the TV better while offering all the basic entertainment applications that you would need on an internet enabled device. Sure most Smart TVs manage to tick all the boxes in terms of the interface/OS offering all key features, but the way you access them and the user interface can be a nightmarish experience. And, it isn't just about a steep learning curve, issues such as slow response times of menus and awful pointer-based navigation will make you cringe each and every time that you use them. So, while Smart TVs do bring internet access and device sharing capabilities, they unfortunately are still away from being smart enough in terms of a

smooth, seamless experience. Having said that, there are a few good WebOS based Smart TVs in the market from LG which offer better UI and overall experience and we also expect TVs based on special Android versions for TV to get introduced this year. So, better (and smarter) smart TVs are around the corner. Buyers who plan to make heavy use of the smart features of the TV and use them frequently for web access should particularly ensure that they check the interface and overall usability quotient of the TVs apart from just matching the spec requirement.

Don't bother with 3D:

Yup, nothing much to say here, unless the 3D feature comes at no extra cost, don't go hunting specifically for a 3D TV. Content is sparse, implementation is sub-par and 3D is best left and experienced in theaters.



Curved and OLED screens:

OLED TVs do offer the best picture quality in terms of colors, contrast, black levels and also the response time. So, if you are sleeping on wads of cash, go ahead and splurge on that OLED TV, it will surely give you the best visual experience. Curved screens on the other hand are more of a technological achievement rather than a market need. The impact of curved screens is limited to 55-inches and above screen sizes and in our books, the impact itself isn't substantial enough to justify the price difference. Having said that, curved TVs do look awesome and will go a long way in enhancing the aesthetics value of your room. If you do want the best value for your money, curved and OLED TVs aren't recommended at their current price points. Even though current OLED TVs do offer the best overall picture quality, OLED TVs are expected to get cheaper and better over the next 2 years.

Sound:

The race towards slimmer, lighter, TVs has resulted in slimmer, lighter TVs that sound like crap. And, in most cases the sound quality from big screen TVs will be adequate at best. There are certain exceptions, the Sony X9 series for example offers pretty good sound quality out of the box. But, it also demands a heavy premium for doing that. If you aren't going to attach extra set of speakers/home theater to your TV, we strongly recommend you to thoroughly test (more on this later) the sound quality of the TV at the store before making your final decision. Poor sound quality can heavily mar the final experience of a big screen TV, we've come across numerous examples of frustrated buyers who are in utter disbelief of how the sound output from their big screen TV is low and highly suppressed in terms of quality and sound stage.

The Jargon: Specs that matter

LED Type: Before going on to the types of LED TVs, let's clear the common misconception around LED TVs. All LED TVs are basically LCD panels with LED based backlight. The type of implementation of light source for the panel using LED arrays has a big role to play in the final picture quality. Most TVs in the market today are edge lit, meaning the LED arrays that light up the panel are placed at the edges of the panel, right along the bezels of the TV. The next type of LED TVs are the 'Direct LED panels', here the LED clusters are placed behind the panel, these TVs generally tend to be a little more bulkier than the edge-lit LED TVs. The third and rare type of backlighting is the 'full array' backlighting, this is similar to direct LED in terms of LEDs being placed behind the LED panel but full array denotes that evenly lit panel due to higher number of LEDs placed evenly across the entire panel rather than the cluster method used in Direct LEDs. All three LED backlight implementations can be supported via 'local dimming' technology. Local dimming offers better contrast and more balanced image quality, thanks to the ability to control LEDs as per the image displayed on the screen. The combination of Full array backlit LED panels with local dimming technology is the best one in terms of image quality. Unfor-